Mentoring Philosophy

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The difference between what someone is capable of and what they ultimately achieve often lies in the opportunities they are given to learn. To me, mentoring means opening doors, making difficult concepts approachable, and helping others recognize their potential. Few things are as rewarding as witnessing that "eureka" moment when someone understands something they once found intimidating. My appreciation for education is rooted in my upbringing in Egypt, where access to knowledge and opportunities is not always equal. Some of my grandparents' older siblings never had the opportunity to attend school, while my grandparents received an education. All were intelligent, capable people and respected community leaders, yet their circumstances shaped different futures for them and their children. This taught me that education is not a measure of intelligence, but a means of expanding possibilities across generations and giving people the opportunity to discover what they are good at and what they are passionate about most. Having benefited from educational opportunities myself, I hope to extend them to others.

My experiences as a mentee have also shaped the mentor I aspire to be. At times, mentors questioned my ability to pursue opportunities, such as applying to graduate school, before I had even tried. Hearing those doubts from people I respect made me question my abilities. Yet I realized that even experienced mentors cannot predict someone's potential, and allowing their doubts to prevent us from trying means never discovering what might have been possible. These experiences taught me how deeply a mentor's words can affect someone's confidence. Rather than letting my assumptions limit a mentee, I want to ask whether I have provided the guidance, resources, and encouragement they need to succeed.

My desire to encourage rather than limit someone's potential also shapes how I approach teaching, where I prioritize encouragement, curiosity, and a sense of belonging. I value interactive, collaborative learning through exchanging ideas, asking questions, and even making mistakes, which can deepen understanding. I encourage participation, even when answers are incorrect, because understanding why something does not work can be as valuable as knowing the correct answer. To make discussions more meaningful, I encourage mentees to familiarize themselves with new topics beforehand and reflect afterward on what they learned, what became clearer, and what remains challenging. These reflections help me understand their progress and adapt my guidance accordingly. I also enjoy connecting unfamiliar concepts to familiar experiences. While mentoring a biology undergraduate who found chromatography column fabrication intimidating, I compared the process to a pencil, using sharpening to illustrate how a laser shapes the column tip and graphite to visualize the packing material inside the column. Watching the student move from following instructions to asking why each step mattered reminded me that effective teaching begins with understanding the learner's perspective.

Through my mentoring experiences, I have learned that meaningful mentoring requires mutual commitment, clear expectations, and open communication. I want mentees to feel comfortable expressing their needs, asking questions, and providing feedback while taking an active role in their learning. I aim to establish shared goals and revisit them regularly, recognizing that the support someone needs may change over time. When challenges arise, I want to listen before making assumptions, whether the difficulty involves unfamiliar concepts, competing priorities, or an overwhelming workload. Together, we can break challenges into manageable steps and identify the support needed. To help mentees develop independence, I begin with familiar tasks, introduce new challenges with guidance, and gradually step back as their skills and confidence grow.

Ultimately, I hope to be remembered not simply for the knowledge I shared, but for the confidence I helped build and the opportunities I helped create. Perhaps the most beautiful part of mentoring is that while we hope to make a difference in someone else's life, they may make a difference in ours, too.